



Student Name:

English Language Arts 20-1

Modern Drama Unit

Modern Drama:

The Crucible

By Arthur Miller

***Sherwood Park:* 464-1899**

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The Crucible

English Language Arts 20-1

Revised June 2018

The Modern Play

Seeing or reading a play may be a familiar experience for you, or it may be somewhat unusual. Think, for a moment, about the plays that you've read and seen, or acted in.

Write a response about your experiences with drama. consider the following questions:

- Can you recall performing skits in school when you were younger?
- As a child, did you act out familiar stories or invent characters and play various roles?
- what were your favourite roles in your childhood dramatizations?
- Have you ever taken a drama class?
- Do you enjoy performing in plays, or do you prefer to be a spectator?

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Reading and Staging a Play

Every play begins with a script. The playwright conceives characters, conflict, and a theme, then these ideas are transformed into a script. Once the script is completed, the playwright either publishes the script, or finds a director or producer interested in the play. The producer is similar to a business manager - his/her job is to find financing for the play, locate a theatre for rehearsals and performance, arrange publicity, and hire the director, designers, actors, and other personnel.

Stage manager: locates the necessary props, helps set the rehearsal schedule,supports the cast.	Set Designer: the person who designs and creates the set and backdrop that is needed for the play.	Lighting and Sound technicians: lighting and sound are essential components if a play is to run smoothly.
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Tips for Reading a Play

- Pay attention to the stage directions as these words, usually written in italics, indicate to the actors how they should move or say their lines.
- whenever possible, read the lines out loud in order to bring the words to life.
- try to imagine what particular gestures and movements might be used with the dialogue.
- Notice the entrances and exits ofthe actors. which characters are on stage during a particular conversation or action?

1. **Read** the following excerpt from a script:

Doorbell rings. Andrea, who has been lying on the couch reading a magazine, rises and answers the door.

Andrea: Hi.

Courier: *(standing in doorway)* I have a package for Ms Danielle Hoffman.

Andrea: She isn't here right now. I'll take it for her.

Courier: Sure. Sign here please. *(hands her a clipboard and pen; brief pause as she signs; then hands her a package)* Thanks.

Andrea: *(holding the package, closes door; stares at address on package; frowns and speaks quietly to herself)* Now why would Danielle be getting a package from a federal prison? *(hears sounds of someone coming to the door; looks around the room; quickly hides package behind a plant)*

Stage directions provide important information for people reading scripts.

a) Choose two stage directions used in the excerpt and explain how they assist the audience in understanding the situation.

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b) **Identify** two ways in which mystery and suspense are created in this script.

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2. **Convert** the following dialogue into the beginning of a scene in a script. Complete the scene within one page. You do not have to complete the story, just the scene that provides suspense. Leave the audience curious about what will happen next. The excerpt from the previous question is an example of script format. Use the directions that follow to assist your audience in visualizing the scene/situation.

- Give the characters names and decide on their relationship.
- Use stage directions to indicate how you want the characters to look, speak, and behave in the scene.
- Choose a setting for this dialogue and use stage directions to explain it for the audience.
- Use italics to indicate stage directions.

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X: Hi, how are you?
Y: I'm not quite sure.
X: What do you mean?
Y: Well, I've had a strange day.
X: What happened?
Y: Do you remember Jason Ells?
X: Yeah. Wasn't he...

Background to *The Crucible*

The Crucible is a 1953 play by American playwright Arthur Miller. It is a dramatized and partially fictionalized story of the Salem witch trials that took place in the Massachusetts Bay Colony during 1692/93. Miller wrote the play as an allegory for McCarthyism, when the United States government persecuted people accused of being communists in the 1950's. Miller himself was questioned by the House of Representatives Committee on Un-American Activities in 1956 and convicted of contempt of Congress for refusing to identify others present at meetings he had attended. Check out the link:
http://blog.ac-versailles.fr/leuro/public/McCarthyism_and_Hollywood.pdf

Act One

Please read Act One and then answer the following questions. For the questions marked with an asterisk (*) please find specific quotes from the text to support your response.

1. What is the time and place of the action of this play?

*2. How does Abigail defend herself when Rev. Parris asks her about her reputation?

*3. Why does Parris hesitate to admit the presence of witchcraft in his community?

4. Why was Thomas Putnam a deeply embittered and vindictive man? What was Mrs. Putnam upset about?

5. How was Tituba involved in the activities of Abigail and her friends?

6. Who is the leader of the girls? What were they doing in the forest?

7. What kind of girl is Mary Warren?

8. What was John Proctor's reputation with the townspeople? Why has he been absent from church?

*9. What are Proctor's feelings for Abigail at this point in the play?

10. Why did some members of the community resent Rebecca and Francis Nurse?

11. Why do some of his parishioners resent Rev. Parris?

12. Parris is the third minister in seven years, what does this tell you about the town?

*13. Why has Rev. Hale been brought to Salem from Andover? How does he feel about his mission?

*14. Why does Mrs. Putnam feel something is behind the death of her children?

*15. What bothers Giles Corey about his wife?

16. How do you explain Tituba's confession? Why does she name Goody Good and Goody Osborn?

17. Why does Abigail begin naming people?

18. Describe the dramatic note upon which this act ends.

Act Two

Please read Act Two and then answer the following questions. For the questions marked with an asterisk (*) please find specific quotes from the text to support your response.

1. What has happened in the eight days that have elapsed between Acts I and II?

2. Explain the conflict that exists between Elizabeth and John Proctor and the particular reason for Elizabeth's becoming angry in this scene?

3. What is your opinion of John Proctor's reaction to his wife's coldness?

*4. Why was Mary Warren away from her duties at the Proctors?

*5. Why was Sarah Good found guilty of witchcraft?

*6. What kind of “blackmail” does Mary use on Elizabeth?

7. Who might cry out against Elizabeth? Why?

8. Why might it be dangerous for someone to call out against Elizabeth but not against Good or Osborne?

9. What are some of the facts Rev. Hale finds suspicious about Proctor, which the court will later hold against him?

10. What does Proctor mean when he says a man may pray to God without golden candlesticks upon the altar?

11. What are the specific witchcraft charges brought against the wives of Francis Nurse and Giles Corey?

12. Who is Cheever and why has he come to Proctor's house?

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13. What part does a poppet play in the action? How does Abigail use the poppet to achieve her own ends?

14. How does Rev. Hale react to the arrests of these women?

15. What is the allusion to Pontius Pilate? Why does Proctor call Hale this?

16. What does Proctor want Mary Warren to do? What will Abigail do to avenge herself?

Act Three

Please read Act Three and then answer the following questions. For the questions marked with an asterisk (*) please find specific quotes from the text to support your response.

1. What is Elizabeth's condition at the time of her arrest?

2. What bargain does Governor Danforth offer to Proctor? Why does Proctor refuse his proposition?

3. Why does Parris keep at Proctor? Why does he tell Danforth that the "man is mischief"?

4. What is the point of the deposition Proctor gives to Danforth?

*5. What is Danforth's decision concerning the 91 persons who signed the deposition?

6. Explain the contents of Corey's deposition. Giles says Putnam has an ulterior motive in having Jacobs called out as a witch. What is it?

7. Why won't Corey give his informant's name to the judge? Why is he then charged?

8. What is Rev. Hale's attitude toward the court in this act?

9. Explain the meaning of Danforth's speech.

10. How does Proctor try to stop Abigail from winning? How is this last effort of his foiled?

11. What is spectral evidence?

*12. Why can't Mary Warren behave now the way she did during the trials?

13. How does Elizabeth's testimony hurt her husband?

14. How do you explain their hysterical behavior?

Act Four

Please read Act Four and then answer the following questions. For the questions marked with an asterisk (*) please find specific quotes from the text to support your response.

1. How has Tituba changed since she last appeared in Act I?

2. What is Rev. Hale doing back in Salem? Why is "damnation doubled on a minister who counseled men to lie"?

3. What ails Parris?

4. The star witness is missing and yet the madness continues. Why?

*5. Why won't Danforth pardon the seven?

6. Why did many people confess to witchery?

7. Why is it important to the officials that accused persons like John Proctor and Rebecca Nurse confess?

*8. What argument does Hale use to convince Elizabeth that she should urge her husband to confess to witchcraft?

*9. Why does Proctor not confess? Why did he consider confessing?

10. Why was Corey pressed rather than hanged? Why did it profit him to "die Christian"?

11. At their last meeting to what sin does Elizabeth confess? How do they relate to each other now?

12. When John begins to confess why is Danforth relieved? Why does Parris welcome the news?

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13. Why does Rebecca say it will damn her if she confesses?

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14. What is Proctor's final decision and what prompts him to make it?

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## **End of The Crucible**